

Reading

Reading

An Underground City

Before you read

- Have you ever heard of a city built entirely underground?
- What do you think life might have been like living below the surface?

In the region of Cappadocia, in central Türkiye, several underground cities can be found carved into the soft volcanic rock. One of the largest of these was discovered almost by accident in 1963, when a local resident knocked down a wall in his house and found a hidden tunnel behind it. Since then, many chambers, corridors and rooms have been uncovered by archaeologists.

It is believed that the underground city was first used thousands of years ago as a place of shelter. Over time, rooms were carved deeper and deeper into the rock, and the settlement was gradually expanded until it could hold thousands of people along with their animals and food supplies. Stables, kitchens, storage rooms and even small churches were built several levels below the ground.

Large round stones were used as doors, and these could be rolled across the entrances from the inside to block invaders. Fresh air was supplied through a clever system of ventilation shafts that also reached the surface, and wells were dug to provide clean water even during long periods underground.

Today, only a small part of the underground city is open to visitors, since new tunnels and rooms are still being explored. It has become one of the most popular attractions in the region, and it is visited by travellers from all over the world who want to see how people once lived beneath the earth.

1. When was the underground city discovered?

- a. In ancient times
- b. In 1963
- c. Last year
- d. It has never been discovered

2. The underground city was used only for one day at a time. — *True / False*

3. Large round stones were used as _____ that could be rolled across entrances.

4. How was fresh air supplied to the underground city?

- a. Through open windows
- b. Through ventilation shafts
- c. It was not supplied
- d. Through the main entrance only

5. Rewrite this sentence in the passive: 'People are still exploring new tunnels and rooms.' (*New tunnels and rooms ...*)

6. Why is only a small part of the underground city open to visitors?

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- a. It is too dangerous
- b. New tunnels and rooms are still being explored
- c. It is closed for repairs
- d. Tourists are not allowed inside

After you read

- Would you like to visit an underground city like this? Why or why not?
- What other reasons might people have had for building homes underground?

A City Built on Water

Before you read

- Do you know of any famous cities built on water or beside a strait?
- What difficulties do you think a city built between two seas might have?

Istanbul is one of the few cities in the world that is built on two continents, with the Bosphorus strait dividing its European and Asian sides. For thousands of years, the city has been ruled by different empires, and each civilisation has left behind its own buildings, walls and monuments.

The old city walls, parts of which can still be seen today, were originally constructed to protect the city from land and sea attacks. Massive gates were built into the walls, and guards were once stationed at each one to check everyone entering the city. Although much of the wall has been damaged over the centuries, sections of it have been carefully restored so that visitors can imagine how strong the defences once were.

One of the city's most famous buildings began its life as a church, was later converted into a mosque, and for many years was used as a museum before being reopened as a mosque again. Its enormous dome, which amazed visitors when it was completed, is still considered an outstanding achievement of engineering.

Today, bridges and tunnels connect the two sides of the city, and thousands of commuters cross the strait every single day. Ferries are still used by many people, partly because they are convenient and partly because the crossing offers wonderful views of the city's skyline. New museums and cultural centres are being opened all the time, which shows that this ancient city continues to change while its history is carefully preserved.

1. What divides the European and Asian sides of the city described?

- a. A mountain range
- b. The Bosphorus strait
- c. A desert
- d. A large lake

2. The old city walls were originally built to _____ the city from attacks.

3. The famous domed building described has always been used only as a mosque. — *True / False*

4. How do most commuters cross between the two sides of the city today?

- a. Only by ferry
- b. By bridges, tunnels, and ferries
- c. By walking across the strait
- d. The crossing is not possible

5. Rewrite in the passive: 'People are opening new museums all the time.' (*New museums ...*)

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After you read

- What do you think makes a city special when it is built between two continents?
- Which parts of a city's history do you think are most important to preserve?